economic glory days are far behind it, and it never successfully translated its still comparatively powerful economy into political influence, let alone a military that could dominate the region. Perceptions of its sclerotic political system, despite the achievements of Abe since 2012, add to the sense that Japan will likely never again regain the dynamism it showed in the postwar decades.

Yet as a stable democracy with a largely content, highly educated, healthy (if aging) population, Japan is still regarded as the benchmark for many Asian nations. Having long ago tackled its pollution problem and boasting a low crime rate, Japan offers an attractive model for developing societies. Its benign international policies and minimal overseas military operations, combined with its generous foreign aid, make Japan the most admired country in Asia, according to a 2015 Pew Research Center poll—71 percent of respondents voiced a favorable view. China garnered only a 57 percent approval rating, with fully one-third of respondents having a negative view.[26]

But current perception and likability benefit Japan only so much. When Genron NPO, the Japanese polling company, asked in 2016 if Japan would increase its influence in Asia by 2026, only 11.6 percent of Chinese and 23 percent of South Koreans answered in the affirmative; perhaps surprisingly, only 28.5 percent of Japanese themselves thought so.[27] When Genron asked the same question about China in 2015, fully 82.5 percent of Chinese, 80 percent of South Koreans, and 60 percent of Japanese expected China's influence in Asia to increase by 2025.[28] Two decades of Chinese economic growth and Japanese economic stagnation undoubtedly are the causes of such findings, but China's recent political overtures under Xi Jinping likely play some role.

Despite scoring lower than Japan in regional opinion polls, China has ridden a wave of anticipation that its ultimate strength will make it the most dominant nation in the Indo-Pacific, if not the world. This has made it easier to attract cooperation or wary neutrality from Asian nations. The AIIB is just one example of Asian nations flocking to a Chinese proposal; One Belt One Road is another. Beijing has also used its influence in negative ways, for example by pressuring Southeast